



The Sikorsky flying boat over New York City, 1932

Great Manufacturers Sikorsky

Known for his key role in the history of helicopter evolution, Sikorsky was a pioneer of large multi-engine fixed-wing aircraft who rose to prominence in the 1930s. From the early days of search and rescue to helicopters for military and commercial use, the company continues to lead the field in innovation and design.

ONE OF THE MOST influential men in the history of helicopter design, Igor Sikorsky was born in the Ukraine in 1889. He was interested in science from a young age and during an early trip to Germany he came across the work of the Wright brothers. He immediately decided that his future lay in aviation.

After studying engineering in Paris and enjoying some early success in building planes in Russia, Sikorsky emigrated to the US in 1919. Initially, he worked as a schoolteacher before setting up his own company—Sikorsky Aero Engineering Corp—in 1923, mostly with the help of Russian immigrants. With their support, he built and flew one of the first twin-engined aircraft in the US, the S-29A. In 1929, the company became part of



Igor Sikorsky
(1889-1972)

the present-day United Technologies Corporation, and Sikorsky's talents were used to design a series of large flying boats for commercial and military use. During this time he maintained his interest in vertical flight, filing patent applications

in 1929 and 1931 and watching the progress of helicopter development in Europe. Great Britain, France, and Germany had all flown successful helicopters by 1939, but the outbreak of war saw

only German development continuing, opening up opportunities for Sikorsky to try to catch up. His first successful helicopter, the VS-300, began testing in September 1939 in Connecticut. To begin with, it was hard to control and, like most early helicopters at test stage, it was tied to the ground with cables. A number of improvements



Sikorsky SH-3 Sea King

Astronauts from the 1969 Apollo 12 moon landing mission await collection by a SH-3 Sea King helicopter. The Sea King has also been used for disaster relief efforts.

With the success of the VS-300, Sikorsky was able to develop his first helicopters for the US Army Air Force. The R-4 carried out the first-ever helicopter rescue mission and pioneered anti-submarine missions with the US Coast Guard and Royal Navy. The beginning of the 1950s saw the introduction of bigger helicopters to carry troops into battle.

the cabin in the S-61, the turbine engine provided not only ample passenger space but greatly improved performance, marking a dramatic change in helicopter development.

“The helicopter’s role in saving lives represents one of the most glorious pages in the history of human flight.”

IGOR SIKORSKY

were made before it was able to fly freely in May 1940. The design was finalized in 1941 with the “penny farthing” layout of a main lifting rotor and a small directional tail rotor.

Sikorsky S-38

This advertisement for the Sikorsky S-38 from c. 1960 shows the amphibious plane being used for island hops in Hawaii.



These aircraft increased the cabin space by moving the bulky piston engines to the nose and became the focus of Sikorsky production.

The arrival of the smaller and lighter but more powerful turbine engine for use in helicopters from the late 1950s was to revolutionize Sikorsky's designs. Placed on top of

A boat-shaped hull and outrigger floats gave the aircraft an amphibious capability, while the twin engines provided a degree of safety in the event of one failing.

By the late 1960s Sikorsky was developing even larger helicopters. The veteran designer had long seen a flying crane among his visions and